Smithsonian's American Latino Museum Gets a Permanent Home

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For six years, the National Museum of the American Latino has existed without a building of its own. Now that is about to change.

In August, the Smithsonian's **Board of Regents** voted to give the museum a **permanent** home in the Arts and Industries Building. This 145-year-old **landmark** sits on the National Mall in Washington, D.C. The Smithsonian already owns the building, so it can move ahead without asking Congress to approve a new site. President Trump has criticized the Smithsonian and proposed cutting funding for the museum, and using an existing building avoids a possible political fight.

Jorge Zamanillo is the museum's **founding director**. He told PBS NewsHour that people worked for more than 30 years to create the museum, with support from both political parties. They felt Latinos were not well represented in Smithsonian museums or in museums across the country. In December 2020, a law was passed creating the museum to help people understand Latino culture and the impact Latinos have had in the United States.

Zamanillo said the building is **symbolic** because it is right at the heart of the Mall. He said the museum could expand the building and even double its space. The Arts and Industries Building was the Smithsonian's first national museum, opening in 1881, and it will now also be home to the Smithsonian's newest museum.

He explained that Latinos are not all the same. The museum wants to show the shared experiences and many different stories of Latinos across centuries of American history.

When asked about political pressure, Zamanillo said the museum always goes back to **scholarship** and facts. When his team meets people around the country, they do not ask about religion or politics. Instead, they look for meaningful stories and objects to collect.

Word Treasure

permanent -- Meant to last for a long time or forever, not just for a while.
Board of Regents -- The group of leaders who make big decisions for the Smithsonian.
landmark -- A famous building or place that is important to history.
symbolic -- Standing for an important idea or meaning beyond what something simply is.
scholarship -- Careful, serious study and research by experts.
founding director -- The first leader of a new organization, who helps build it from the start.

Background you need

The Smithsonian Institution is a group of national museums and research centers, many of them along the National Mall in Washington, D.C.

The National Mall is a long park lined with museums and monuments, and it is one of the most visited places in the country.

Congress passes laws to create new national museums, and finding and paying for a building can take many years.

The National Museum of the American Latino was created to share the history, culture and contributions of Latinos in the United States.

Break it down

LEAD: The National Museum of the American Latino will finally get a building of its own

KEY EVENT: The Smithsonian's Board of Regents voted in August to use the Arts and Industries Building

+- WHERE: A 145-year-old landmark on the National Mall in Washington, D.C.

+- WHY THIS BUILDING: The Smithsonian owns it, so no new congressional approval is needed

CONTEXT: President Trump has criticized the Smithsonian and proposed cutting the museum's funding

HISTORY: More than 30 years of bipartisan effort; a law created the museum in December 2020

DIRECTOR'S VIEW: Jorge Zamanillo says the site is symbolic and the museum will show many Latino stories

OPEN QUESTION: Which stories and objects will the museum collect and display?

Why it matters

National museums shape how Americans learn their shared history, and this decision gives Latino history a lasting place at the center of the National Mall.

Test what you remember

1. **Where will the National Museum of the American Latino have its permanent home?**
   - (A) The Arts and Industries Building on the National Mall
   - (B) A building in Miami
   - (C) The White House
   - (D) A new building in New York
2. **Who voted in August to give the museum this home?**
   - (A) Congress
   - (B) The Smithsonian's Board of Regents
   - (C) The U.S. Supreme Court
   - (D) The city of Washington, D.C.
3. **Why can the Smithsonian move ahead without asking Congress to approve a new site?**
   - (A) Because it already owns the building
   - (B) Because Congress is on break
   - (C) Because the museum is private
   - (D) Because the building is temporary
4. **How long did people work to create the museum, according to Jorge Zamanillo?**
   - (A) Exactly ten years
   - (B) More than 30 years
   - (C) About two years
   - (D) About 145 years
5. **When did the Arts and Industries Building open as the Smithsonian's first national museum?**
   - (A) 1881
   - (B) 2020
   - (C) 1945
   - (D) 1776
6. **What does Zamanillo say the museum always goes back to when facing political pressure?**
   - (A) Opinion polls
   - (B) Ticket sales
   - (C) Famous visitors
   - (D) Scholarship and facts

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: B 3: A 4: B 5: A 6: D

Questions to think about

1. Jorge Zamanillo (founding director): The museum fills a gap in Latino representation, the site is symbolic, and the museum relies on scholarship and facts rather than politics.

2. President Trump: Has criticized the Smithsonian and proposed cutting funding for the museum.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):